

Text One

9 reasons why young people should spend more time outdoors

adapted from an article by Naomi Dunbar

In this passage, the writer tries to persuade readers of the benefits of spending more time outdoors.



It wasn't until I rediscovered the outdoors in my early twenties that I realised how unhealthy and unhappy the 'sit on my phone and watch telly, couch potato'¹ lifestyle was for me, and not only how spending time outdoors could make such a significant difference in my life, but how enjoyable it was.

Don't get me wrong, I still watch cat videos on Facebook and binge on Netflix every now and again. We found nine definitive reasons why young people should spend more time outdoors. So, listen up...

5

1. Improves and strengthens mental health

Sadly, mental health issues such as anxiety and depression have never been higher in young people than today, and with growing pressure from the media, social platforms, and smartphones being attached to us like another limb, it's not hard to see why. So, it's time to ditch the Wi-Fi and get yourself outdoors. Why? Because many psychological studies have shown that spending time in nature has an extremely positive impact on your mental and emotional health.

10

2. Being outdoors reduces stress

15

Whether it's work, study or social-related, most young people encounter stress in their daily lives. Well, if you've ever gone for a quick walk while feeling stressed, you'll know the difference it can make to your mood. Being outside and immersing yourself in nature



helps you to switch off from the worries that hang over your head, and disconnecting yourself from civilisation will help to give you a well-deserved break.	20
3. It's healthier for your eyes	
We're all guilty of it. As a society, with smartphones, computers and televisions being more technologically advanced than ever, we're spending an unhealthy amount of hours staring at screens every day. So, it's not hard to see why spending time in the outdoors will be healthier for your eyes, because not only will we not be staring at screens, but it also takes us away from environments with harsh artificial lighting, such as offices and homes.	25
4. Increases memory and attention span	
Scientific studies have proved that spending time in the outdoors can help to strengthen our ability to concentrate – even just a little bit of fresh air and sunshine can increase your attention span. So, if you're finding it hard to concentrate, why not ditch the work and take a break outside?	30
5. You'll get a good dose of vitamin D	
With society as a whole spending less time outside, you'll find that many of us are not getting enough vitamin D into our systems. Our bodies absorb vitamin D from the sun when we spend time in sunlight. Not absorbing enough of the vitamin can cause vitamin D deficiency, which has symptoms such as fatigue, depression, hair loss, bone weakness and muscle pain.	35
6. You'll sleep better	
If you're struggling to sleep and find yourself counting sheep at night, you may find it's because you're spending too much time cooped up indoors. So, if you're spending too much time indoors you may just find that your sleep cycle is likely to suffer as a result of this.	40
7. Your physical health will improve	
This one is pretty self-explanatory. Being active outside is a fantastic form of exercise that is enjoyable and will greatly impact your health. You'll also find that you have more energy. So, whether it's a stroll in the park or hiking in the hills, being regularly active in the outdoors can help combat many health issues such as high blood pressure, heart disease and obesity.	45
8. It helps you to reflect and think more clearly	50
Having that physical break from your phone, daily stresses and busy civilisation really helps you to take a step back, think more reflectively and clearly. I can vouch for how much conquering a mountain (of any size) or successfully hiking a trail can put life problems into perspective and will help you to think about things in a more logical manner. It's magnificent what a bit of fresh air can do to you – and the best part? It's completely free of charge!	55
9. You'll feel happier	
With the above points all working together in harmony when you spend time in the great outdoors, it's obvious that you'll start feeling much happier. It's just up to you to make that conscious decision to spend a little more time outside – be it an evening	60

walk, popping outside in your lunch break or forcing yourself to get off the couch on the weekend and enjoy an incredible coastal walk. And let's face it, the outdoors is our natural environment!

*couch potato*¹ – a lazy and inactive person, especially one who spends a great deal of time watching television



Text Two

A Walk in the Woods

adapted from a travel book by Bill Bryson

In this passage, the writer describes the start of his walk along the 2,190 mile Appalachian Trail in eastern USA.



The route led down into a wooded valley with a chuckling stream edged with brittle ice, which the path followed for perhaps half a mile before taking us steeply up into denser woods. This was, it quickly became evident, the base of the first big hill, Frosty Mountain, and it was immediately tiring. The sun was shining and the sky was a hearty blue, but everything at ground level was brown – brown trees, brown earth, frozen brown leaves – and the cold was unyielding. I trudged perhaps a hundred feet up the hill, then stopped, bug-eyed, breathing hard, heart kabooming alarmingly. I pressed on.

5

It was hell. First days on hiking trips always are. I was hopelessly out of shape – hopelessly. The pack weighed way too much. Way too much. I had never encountered anything so hard, for which I was so ill-prepared. Every step was a struggle.

10

The hardest part was coming to terms with the constant dispiriting discovery that there is always more hill. The thing about being on a hill, as opposed to standing back from it, is that you can almost never see exactly what's to come. Between the curtain of trees at every side, the ever-receding contour of rising slope before you, and your own plodding weariness, you gradually lose track of how far you have come. Each time you haul yourself up to what you think must surely be the crest, you find that there is in fact more hill beyond, sloped at an angle that kept it from view before, and that beyond that slope there is another, and beyond that another and another, and beyond each of those more still, until it seems impossible that any hill could run on this long.

15

20

Eventually you reach a height where you can see the tops of the topmost trees, with nothing but clear sky beyond, and your faltering spirit stirs – nearly there now! – but this is a pitiless deception. The summit continually retreats by whatever distance you press forward, so that each time the trees part enough to give a view you are dismayed to see that the topmost trees are as remote, as unattainable, as before. Still you stagger on. What else can you do? 25

When, after ages and ages, you finally reach the tell-tale world of truly high ground, where the chilled air smells of pine sap and the vegetation is gnarled and tough and wind bent, and push through to the mountain's open summit, you are, alas, past caring. You sprawl face down, pressed to the rock by the weight of your pack, and lie there for some minutes, reflecting in a distant, out-of-body way that you have never before looked this closely at lichen¹, not in fact looked this closely at anything in the natural world since you were four years old and had your first magnifying glass. Finally, with a weary puff, you roll over, unhook yourself from your pack, struggle to your feet, and realize – again in a remote, light-headed, curiously not-there way – that the view is sensational: a boundless vista of wooded mountains, unmarked by human hand, marching off in every direction. This really could be heaven. It's splendid, no question, but the thought you cannot escape is that you have to walk this view, and this is the barest fraction of what you will cross before you've finished. 30 35

But, of course, I had all that ahead of me. Today I had nothing to do but cross four average mountains over seven miles of well-marked trail in clear, dry weather. It didn't seem too much to ask. It was hell. 40

Seven miles seems so little, but it's not, believe me. With a pack, even for fit people it is not easy. OK, now imagine something inert but weighty, something that doesn't want to be lifted, that makes it abundantly clear to you as soon as you pick it up that what it wants is to sit heavily on the ground – say, a bag of cement – in any case, forty pounds of profound heaviness. Imagine walking with that weight for hours, for days, and not along level paths with benches and refreshment booths at thoughtful intervals but over a rough trail, full of sharp rocks and unyielding roots and staggering ascents that transfer enormous amounts of strain to your pale, shaking thighs. Don't tell me that seven miles is not far. 45 50

And so I trudged along for hours, in a private little world of weariness and woe, up and over imposing hills, through an endless mass of trees, all the time thinking: 'I must have done seven miles by now, surely.' But always the wandering trail ran on.

*lichen*¹ – grey, green or yellow plant-like organism that lives on rocks and trees

